

enthusiasm.

‘Having seen two more Diwalis than you in this trading ring, I can tell you one thing confidently. No matter how big or accomplished a player, nobody can correctly predict the top or bottom of a stock,’ he said.

I still went ahead, and short-sold the stock at around Rs 3,150. Over the next week, the stock gained Rs 100 as the market as a whole started rising again. I met up with Sharma over tea a few days after I had short-sold ACC. We discussed many stocks, and towards the end of our conversation I casually asked him about ACC.

The seasoned trader that he was, Sharma could deduce which side of the trade a market player was on from his very tone.

‘You are trying too hard to be indifferent about ACC, which tells me that you are in a spot of bother. In case you have been stupid enough to short-sell ACC, my advice to you would be to square immediately,’ he said with a wry smile.

‘Okay, I will be upfront. I am short on the stock. How high can it go from here?’ I asked.

‘Bhai says it can go to a level beyond anybody’s imagination,’ Sharma said.

‘And what is that level likely to be?’ I asked.

‘You seem to be a bit hard of hearing. I just said beyond anybody’s imagination, and that holds for me as well. Honestly, Lala, I don’t think even Bhai would have expected ACC to come so close to hitting Rs 4,000; and it is very likely he does not know how high it can go from here either,’ Sharma said.

My chat with Sharma made me a bit nervous about my trade, and I regretted having spoken to him. With the stock price showing no signs of weakness, I decided to wait for one more day before squaring up my position. That evening I went over to Prakash’s place at his invitation for dinner. There I met an elderly relative of his, a gentleman in his mid-seventies who had been working at a broker’s office till five years ago. Though not a trader himself, he had many interesting tales to tell.

Soon the conversation veered to the bull run in ACC. I asked him if he recollected having seen anything like this during his career in the stock market. ‘Crazy things used to happen in the market even then,’ he said, after mulling over my question. ‘I remember a similar bull run in the shares of Tata deferred (‘deferred’ being a class of shares back then) sometime in